

THE DAILY FINANCE BRIEF

Financial News in Plain English

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Personalised for Rishabh Srinivasan

ECONOMY

Homebuyers Struggle as Mortgage Rates Climb Near 7%

As of September 17, 2026, many people looking to buy homes in the U.S. are facing new challenges because mortgage rates are nearing 7%. A mortgage is a loan specifically for purchasing a home, and the interest rate is the cost of borrowing that money. The average 30-year fixed-rate mortgage, which means the interest rate stays the same for 30 years, recently reached 6.76%. This increase is due to rising long-term bond yields, which are the returns

investors earn from lending money to the government, and concerns about inflation, which is the general rise in prices over time.

This rise in mortgage rates makes it more expensive for people to borrow money to buy homes, leading to fewer affordable options and slowing down home purchases. This situation is compounded by already high home prices and a limited supply of available homes.

Source: Associated Press

MARKETS

U.S. Stock Futures Climb as Oil Prices Drop

On September 17, 2026, U.S. stock index futures, which are contracts that allow investors to buy stocks at a predetermined price in the future, rose significantly. The S&P 500 (an index that tracks the stock prices of 500 large U.S. companies) futures increased by 0.8%, and the Nasdaq 100 futures rose by 1.1%. This positive movement was attributed to a rally in Treasury bonds, which are government debt securities, and a decline in oil prices. The decrease in oil prices can help lower costs for consumers, as it can lead to cheaper gasoline and energy prices.

This rise in stock futures reflects increased investor confidence and a positive outlook for the market, which can be beneficial for everyday people who have investments in stocks or retirement accounts.

Source: Livemint

Asian Markets Show Resilience After U.S. Interest Rate Hike

On September 17, 2026, Asian stock markets, which are markets where shares of companies are bought and sold in Asia, showed positive momentum despite the Federal Reserve's recent decision to raise interest rates. Investors interpreted the Fed's move as a strong commitment to controlling inflation, which is the general rise in prices of goods and services over time. This resilience in Asian markets suggests optimism about economic stability and growth prospects in the region.

This news is important for ordinary people as it reflects global economic trends that can influence local markets and investments.

Source: Malay Mail

Federal Reserve Raises Interest Rates to Combat Inflation

On September 16, 2026, the Federal Reserve (the U.S. central bank that controls interest rates) raised the federal funds rate by 0.25 percentage points to a target range of 3.75%–4%. This is the first increase in interest rates since 2023 and is aimed at addressing inflation, which is the general rise in prices of goods and services over time. The decision was unanimously supported by the Federal Open Market Committee, indicating a strong commitment to controlling inflation.

This increase in interest rates can affect everyday people by making loans, including mortgages and car loans, more expensive. As borrowing costs rise, consumers may cut back on spending, which can slow down economic growth.

Source: Axios

COMPANIES

SEC Approves New Way to Trade U.S. Stocks Using Blockchain Technology

On September 17, 2026, the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), which is the government agency that regulates the stock market, approved a new way to trade U.S. stocks using blockchain technology. Blockchain is a digital ledger that records transactions securely and transparently. This approval allows blockchain platforms to trade tokenized shares of U.S. companies, which means that ownership rights in a company's shares are converted into digital tokens. This innovation aims to make trading more efficient and accessible for investors.

This development could change how everyday people buy and sell stocks, potentially lowering transaction costs and increasing access to investment opportunities.

Source: Axios

U.S. House Passes Sanctions Bill Targeting Russia's Economy

On September 16, 2026, the U.S. House of Representatives approved a sanctions bill aimed at Russian officials and key sectors of Russia's economy. Sanctions are penalties imposed by one country on another to influence its behavior. This bill includes sanctions on Russian banks, officials, and energy shipping, as well as tariffs, which are taxes on imports, on Russian oil and gas. The goal of this legislation is to cut off financial resources for the war in Ukraine.

This news may not directly impact everyday people in the U.S., but it reflects the government's efforts to address international conflicts and can have broader implications for global economic stability.

Source: Associated Press

Understanding Tokenization of Stocks: What You Need to Know

Tokenization of stocks is the process of converting ownership rights in a company's shares into digital tokens on a blockchain. This technology allows for fractional ownership, meaning that investors can buy a portion of a share rather than a whole share. This concept is in the news today because the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) recently approved blockchain-based trading of tokenized U.S. stocks, which could change how everyday people buy and sell stocks.

This innovation can make investing more accessible and affordable, allowing more individuals to participate in the stock market.

Source: Axios

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